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WR 13300-16: Multimedia Writing and Rhetoric

Saturday October 4th, 2025

Morality in the Northern Renaissance Workplace: A Rhetorical Analysis of Marinus Van
Reymerswaele's painting *The Lawyer's Office*

The Lawyer's Office (c. 1530–1590) by Marinus Van Reymerswaele gives a commentary on greed and moral deterioration in the professional world during the Northern Renaissance. Through its exaggerated features, attention to detail, and symbolism, Van Reymerswaele builds a successful criticism both of work and the societal consequences of immorally created work, while also of office work. This painting is a rhetorical object that gives a warning: when those held responsible for duties fall prey to greed, society experiences a slow, often overlooked deterioration.

Context

This work is a product of the Northern Renaissance, which was a time when realism and moral concern were emphasized in artistic circles. The artists of the Northern Renaissance emphasized the world of materials, everyday existence, and moral themes. Van Reymerswaele's presentations of specific objects, such as coins, papers, and papers on a filing cabinet, illustrate this broader culture of presenting the facts of working existence with accompanying moral shortcomings. Within this context, the stretched quality of the characters and the symbolic compositions have functions that go beyond simple artistic beauties, being contrived devices

which encourage contemplation on the part of viewers concerning morality, work, and societal consequences.

Description + Rhetorical Appeals

At first sight, the viewer's attention is immediately fixed on the center subjects: the client and lawyer. The position of the client and his expression make for a strong appeal to pathos. His body is inclined forward, tense, desperate, with a large bulging vein on his forehead, an indication of stress and frustration. This detail gives rise to the sense of physical and emotional cost of being obliged to cope with a system corrupting due to greed, which evokes sentiment and sympathy from the viewer. The lawyer, meanwhile, overwhelms the composition with an unusually large nose and huge neck, which the artist uses to hint moral depravity. His gaze is fixed not on the despairing client, but on the top papers facing him, which gives rise to a concern for self-interest rather than professional accountability. The disheveled shelf behind him, loaded with documents, also corroborates the appeal to logos: it is evidence of mismanagement, incompleteness, and societal inefficiencies due to greed. Van Reymerswaele's pay attention to such details illustrates the causality between individual greediness and societal damage.

The recourse to rhetoric here on the part of Van Reymerswaele depends primarily on ethos. By the physicality of distended features, the incorporation of symbolic touches such as forsaken documents, and the money, the painter infuses credibility into his ethical judgment. Through such pictorial details, the viewer receives a cue that the sighted findings have a foundation on true behaviors and their results, a reflection of professional ethical fears at the workplace about workplace honesty. Through such a cue, the viewer receives a cue that believe the delivered word of the painting: rampant greed pilfering a position of authority begets certain

tangible negative results. Of equal relevance is the contribution of pathos. The client's suffering, depicted with lurid details, provides the viewer a way towards emotional pathos, a way of envisioning the cost in man-hours of corruption. The logos, the rational link between the lawyer's lack of accountability, the pile of unreceived work orders, and subsequent damage warranted on society, however, provides the painting primary thesis support. Each element within the arrangement is constructed towards the viewer towards a realization of deeper moral devastation.

Finally, *The Lawyer's Office* transcends simple description of a professional lawyer at work; it is an allegorical reflection on the dangers of ethical relaxation and a thirst for power. The allegorical decisions of Van Reymerswaele deliver the punchline that when professional people who hold office fail to do their jobs, through sloth, corruption, or personal interest, society bears the consequences. Necessary work goes unreformed, and societal edifices fall prey to the strain of individual moral frailty. Through examination of the visual rhetoric (exaggerated features, difficult objects, and relationships between figures) the viewer discerns the serious ethical considerations at large. The painting's salience extends beyond the painting's own time, the Northern Renaissance, to a contemporaneous commentary on work.

Conclusion

Briefly, Marinus Van Reymerswaele's *The Lawyer's Office* illustrates the worker rhetoric in its integration of imagery, pathos, logos, and ethos. Through logos, pathos, and ethos, the painting declares: workers' negligence and greediness at work are not individual vices but societal threats. Through seeing the visual details such as the client's urgency, the lawyer's self-centeredness, and the evidentially cluttered proof of abandoned work, observers grasp how professional work-related ethical deficits little by little disintegrate society. Van Reymerswaele's

rhetoric makes such critique not just seen through the painting but experienced. As such, The Lawyer's Office is a compelling object for studying work, morality, and societal accountability.

Works Cited

Van Reymerswaele, Marinus. The Lawyers Office. 1530-1590. Raclin Murphy Museum of Art, Notre Dame.